

An Autistic Parent at Your School

For school staff & teachers — working with an autistic parent at your school.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a parent's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Autistic parents are often **deeply engaged and excellent advocates** for their child — and many recognise their own traits only after their child's assessment. School communication can be a strain: last-minute messages, parents' evenings, phone calls and unstructured events are high-channel and exhausting. A few predictable, written, low-sensory adjustments turn an anxious parent into your strongest partner in the child's education.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Wants everything by email; avoids calls or meetings	Single-channel communication; writing reduces the load — not avoidance
Intense, detailed focus on one issue or routine	A passion for getting it right , plus a need for predictability
Misses the assembly, the fair, the gate chat	Sensory and social overload — not disinterest in their child
Overwhelmed, blunt, or "too much" in a meeting	Autistic inertia + overload; blunt = literal, not rude
Advocates hard — knows the law, the policy, the plan	They are the expert on their child; a great resource, not a threat

Try this

- **Default to written communication** — email, a home-school book, or an agreed app; give notice and a written agenda before any meeting.
- **Be predictable** — scheduled check-ins, advance notice of changes, a quiet space for parents' evenings.
- **Take their expertise seriously** — they know their child's triggers, early signs and what regulates them; co-create the support plan.
- **Keep language literal and concrete**, one topic at a time; allow processing time and written follow-up.
- **Lead on inclusion** — model the neuroaffirming, anti-bullying culture you'd want for their child.

Avoid this

- Surprise phone calls, last-minute changes, or noisy, unstructured school events with no quiet option.
- Reading a blunt email or a missed meeting as hostility or disinterest.
- Discounting their knowledge or framing their advocacy as "difficult."

When to get more support

Recognise that an autistic parent may carry a **high burnout load** and be caring for a neurodivergent child at the same time — coordinate with the SENCO/SEND lead and signpost **autism-led family support**. Where the parent is newly identified, treat them as you'd want a clinician to treat your pupil: with belief and accommodation.

If the parent is a mother

Autistic mothers are frequently misdiagnosed and mask intensely, including with school staff. A “high-functioning” exterior can hide real overload — take a literal, predictable, low-demand approach regardless.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Family guide** (Parts 4 & 6), **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual family.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Pearson & Rose (2021, masking); ASAN (“nothing about us without us”). Full citations are in the source drafts.